CLAIMS

What is claimed is:

1. A method for networking, comprising:

    - encapsulating a data structure representing a mathematical expression into the payload of a data packet;
    - prepending a header to the payload to form a parametric packet, wherein the header contains a destination address in a symbolic or high-radix format;
    - transmitting the parametric packet from a source node onto a network;
    - receiving the packet at an intermediate network node;
    - at the intermediate node, reading only the header to determine a forwarding path; and
    - forwarding the parametric packet, with its payload unmodified, towards the destination address.

2. The method of claim 1, wherein the mathematical expression is unevaluated during its traversal of the intermediate network node.

3. The method of claim 1, wherein the method is implemented across a protocol stack that mirrors the layers of the OSI model but is adapted for parametric data.

4. The method of claim 1, further comprising receiving the packet at a destination node and extracting the complete, unmodified data structure from the payload.

5. A network node, comprising:

    - one or more network interfaces for receiving and transmitting packets;

- a routing table containing symbolic or high-radix addresses;
- a parametric forwarding engine configured to:
  - receive a parametric packet containing a symbolic header and a payload;
  - extract a destination address from the symbolic header;
  - query the routing table using the destination address to determine an outbound interface; and
  - transmit the parametric packet via the outbound interface without evaluating or altering the payload.

6. The network node of claim 5, wherein the payload of the parametric packet contains a data structure representing an unevaluated mathematical expression.

7. A parametric data packet for transmission on a network, comprising:
   - a header field containing a destination address represented as a symbolic or high-radix value; and
   - a variable-length payload field configured to contain a data structure representing a complete, unevaluated mathematical expression.